The Capital of France: A Detailed Geographical and Historical Report

Introduction and Direct Answer

The capital of France is Paris. This conclusion is consistent across all supplied sources. The GS-JJ informational article identifies Paris as "the capital and largest city of France," while the EBSCO geography research starter likewise opens with "Paris, the capital of France," and the Adelphi University overview also states that Paris is the "capital of France" (Carter, 2026; Chittom, 2022; Paris, France, n.d.). Paris is not merely the national capital; it is also the capital of the Île-de-France region and functions as France's political, cultural, and demographic core (Carter, 2026). No source supplied in this task names any other present capital of France. The only historical exception mentioned is the temporary relocation of the capital to Vichy during the German occupation of 1940–1944, a period that ended with the restoration of Paris as the capital (Paris, France, n.d.).

Geographic Position and Administrative Organization

Paris is located in northern France along the Seine River within the region known as Île-de-France (Chittom, 2022; Carter, 2026). The city lies in the middle of the Paris basin and contains some of the oldest settled areas in the city (Carter, 2026). Administratively, Paris is subdivided into twenty political sections known as arrondissements (Chittom, 2022). These arrondissements are numbered according to their distance from the river, and areas of the city are also distinguished by their location north or south of the Seine. Regions south of the river are called the Left Bank, while regions north of the river are known as the Right Bank (Chittom, 2022).

Geographic size data vary according to definition. The GS-JJ article reports that the narrow city of Paris includes only 20 districts within the original Parisian city wall, with an area of 86.928 square kilometers (Carter, 2026). By contrast, the EBSCO research starter gives the Paris metropolitan area as 105 square kilometers, or 41 square miles, and notes that the city rises to an altitude of 129 meters, or 423 feet, above sea level at the top of Montmartre (Chittom, 2022). These figures illustrate the difference between the administrative city proper and broader metropolitan or regional definitions. The Greater Paris region includes the departments of Hauts-de-Seine, Val-de-Marne, and Seine-Saint-Denis, which are located around the walls of Paris and consist of cities connected to Paris (Carter, 2026). This wider area was historically called Île de France (Carter, 2026).

Population and Demographic Context

Population figures for Paris also reflect the difference between the city proper and the wider metropolitan region. The GS-JJ article states that the city of Paris had more than 2.2 million inhabitants and that the 2009 population was more than 2.23 million (Carter, 2026). It records that Paris reached a population record of 2.9 million in 1921, followed by a long period of decline (Carter, 2026). Between 1962 and 1975, many residents moved from central Paris to the suburbs because of high housing prices, deindustrialization, demographic changes, and the development of mass transit systems (Carter, 2026). This population loss had a negative impact on the city, but after municipal government efforts, the population in July 2004 grew for the first time since 1954 (Carter, 2026).

The Adelphi University page provides a closely related figure of 2.234 million inhabitants at the end of 2011 and identifies Paris as the core of the Île-de-France region, which had approximately 12 million people (Paris, France, n.d.). A much larger figure appears in the EBSCO research starter, which states that "the city's population of approximately 11.1 million includes a rich tapestry of cultures, with significant communities from North Africa, the Middle East, and various religious backgrounds" (Chittom, 2022). That 11.1 million figure is best understood in this report as a broader metropolitan or regional population, because it is far larger than the city-proper figures reported by the other two sources. EBSCO also notes that the majority of Parisians are Roman Catholic, with large groups of Muslims and Jews and smaller communities of Protestants and Buddhists (Chittom, 2022).

Historical Development as the Capital of France

Paris has a long history as the political center of France. The city was founded more than 2,000 years ago and has developed into a modern and vibrant city with significant commercial, cultural, academic, scientific, administrative, and business activity (Paris, France, n.d.). According to the Adelphi overview, before Paris became the capital, the capital of France was Lyon under Roman rule (Paris, France, n.d.). Paris first became the capital of France in 508 under King Clovis (Paris, France, n.d.). After several centuries in which France had no unique capital, Paris regained its status as capital under King Philippe Auguste, who reigned between 1180 and 1223 (Paris, France, n.d.). Remains of the Philippe Auguste city wall are reported to be visible in the passageway between the Louvre parking area and the Louvre Museum (Paris, France, n.d.).

Paris has remained the capital of France to the present day, with one four-year interruption. During the German occupation of France in World War II, from 1940 to 1944, the capital of France was

moved to Vichy (Paris, France, n.d.). EBSCO similarly describes Paris as having evolved from a small fishing village into a significant political and cultural center, witnessing events such as the French Revolution and the rise and fall of various regimes (Chittom, 2022). It also notes that Paris remains a symbol of resilience, having faced challenges including occupation during World War II and more recent acts of terrorism (Chittom, 2022).

Landmarks, Culture, and Economic Significance

Paris is internationally known for landmarks that reflect its long political and cultural role. EBSCO identifies the Eiffel Tower, the Louvre Museum, and Notre-Dame Cathedral as globally recognizable attractions (Chittom, 2022). The GS-JJ article names the 12th-century cathedral of Notre Dame, the Arc de Triomphe built by Napoleon I, and the 19th-century Eiffel Tower as the three most famous landmarks in Paris (Carter, 2026). The Eiffel Tower was originally constructed by Gustave Eiffel for the 1889 World's Fair as a temporary structure, but it was not dismantled and has since become a permanent symbol of Paris (Carter, 2026).

The historical axis of Paris is a straight line running from the center of the city westward. The eastern end of this axis begins at the Louvre and passes through the Tuileries Garden, the Place de la Concorde, and the Champs-Élysées before reaching the Arc de Triomphe in the center of Place Charles de Gaulle (Carter, 2026). After the 1960s, the axis continued westward to the La Défense business district, where the Grande Arche stands in the square of La Défense and where most of the skyscrapers in the Paris metropolitan area are concentrated (Carter, 2026). The Invalides Museum contains the tombs of many prominent French soldiers, including Napoleon, and the Panthéon is the burial place of many outstanding French men and women (Carter, 2026). In 1991, numerous places of interest along the Seine River in Paris were included in the World Heritage List (Carter, 2026).

Paris is also a major hub for tourism and international fashion. EBSCO states that Paris received approximately 48 million tourists, including inbound and domestic visitors, in 2024, according to Statista, while Reuters reported that France saw a record-breaking 102 million foreign tourists in 2025, with many visiting Paris (Chittom, 2022). Tourists are attracted by landmarks, art, cuisine, politics, fashion, and sporting events such as the French Open and the Tour de France (Chittom, 2022). The tourism industry contributes greatly to France's annual tourism revenue (Chittom, 2022). The city is also supported by a well-established subway transportation system known as the Metro, a citywide bus system, and Charles de Gaulle International Airport (Chittom, 2022).

The Adelphi page emphasizes that Paris is a world capital of shopping and fashion, naming Chanel, spelled "Channel" in the source, Dior, Vuitton, and Yves Saint Laurent among top French fashion brands (Paris, France, n.d.). It also highlights the continuing French tradition of fine dining in

gastronomic restaurants and excellent family-style places (Paris, France, n.d.). French kings, who governed France from 448 until 1848, commissioned many monuments, including Versailles Palace and the Louvre Museum, while the Catholic Church and Parisians built great churches, including Notre Dame and Sainte-Chapelle (Paris, France, n.d.).

Synthesis of Source Data

The following table consolidates the principal factual claims from the supplied sources. The direct answer to the query is consistent across all sources: the capital of France is Paris. Where figures vary, the variation primarily reflects differences between city-proper, metropolitan, and regional definitions.

Category	Carter (2026)	Chittom (2022)	Paris, France (n.d.)
Capital status	Capital and largest city of France; capital of Île-de-France	Capital of France	Capital of France
Location	Northern France, Paris basin, along the Seine	Northern France, along the Seine, Île-de-France	France, core of Île-de-France
Administration	20 districts within original city wall; Greater Paris includes Hauts-de-Seine, Val-de-Marne, Seine-Saint-Denis	20 arrondissements; Left Bank and Right Bank	Not specified
Area	86.928 square kilometers, city proper	105 square kilometers, metropolitan area	Not specified
Population	More than 2.2 million; 2.23 million in 2009	Approximately 11.1 million, broader/metropolitan	2.234 million at end of 2011; 12 million in Île-de-France
Key landmarks	Notre Dame, Arc de Triomphe, Eiffel Tower, Louvre, Invalides,	Eiffel Tower, Louvre Museum, Notre-Dame Cathedral	Versailles Palace, Louvre,

Category	Carter (2026)	Chittom (2022)	Paris, France (n.d.)
	Panthéon, Seine UNESCO sites		Notre Dame, Sainte-Chapelle
Tourism and economy	Promotional travel statement	48 million tourists in 2024; France 102 million foreign tourists in 2025; Metro, buses, Charles de Gaulle Airport	Shopping, fashion, food tourism

The main factual conclusion is unambiguous: Paris is the capital of France. Differences in population or area statistics do not alter that finding.

Assessment of Sources and Data Reliability

The three supplied sources differ in character and authority. The EBSCO entry, published in 2022 and authored by Lynn-nore Chittom, is the most academically oriented and structured of the three (Chittom, 2022). It provides a broad synthesis and draws on external reporting from Statista and Reuters. However, it sometimes uses the term "city" for what appears to be a larger metropolitan population, as in its reference to approximately 11.1 million people. The GS-JJ article is a commercial blog post from a custom-patch company, dated June 18, 2026 (Carter, 2026). It is newer and offers detailed urban facts, but it is not an official statistical authority. The Adelphi University page provides useful historical information about the capital status of Paris, but it has no visible author or publication date and should therefore be treated cautiously for current demographic claims (Paris, France, n.d.).

Despite these differences, the central finding is robust. No supplied source names any present capital of France other than Paris. The only historical exception mentioned is the temporary relocation to Vichy during the German occupation of 1940–1944, which was explicitly a four-year interruption (Paris, France, n.d.). The identity of France's capital is therefore not in doubt.

Conclusion

The answer to the query "What is the capital of France?" is Paris. Paris is the political and cultural center of France, the capital of the Île-de-France region, and a globally significant center of history, fashion, tourism, and administration (Carter, 2026; Chittom, 2022). Its role as French capital dates to 508 under King Clovis, was consolidated under Philippe Auguste, and has continued to the

present day apart from the 1940–1944 Vichy interlude (Paris, France, n.d.). While population and area figures vary depending on whether the city proper, metropolitan area, or region is being described, the capital designation itself is clear and consistent across all supplied sources.

References

- Carter, E. (2026, June 18). *The capital and largest city of France–Paris*. GS-JJ. https://www.gs-jj.com/blogs/the-capital-and-largest-city-of-franceparis
- Chittom, L. (2022). *Paris, France*. In *Geography and cartography research starters*. EBSCOhost. https://www.ebsco.com/research-starters/geography-and-cartography/paris-france
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